



EMPLOYMENT FIRST

One of the greatest challenges faced by people with mental retardation and other disabilities has been securing and maintaining meaningful employment. Whereas, The Arc believes that every person who wants a job in his or her community should be able to have one and that everyone, regardless of his or her disability, can work in the community if provided the necessary and appropriate supports, the reality is that most adults with mental retardation do not work or work for low wages in segregated settings. Across the country few people with mental retardation work in real jobs and in Tennessee very few people with mental retardation work in the community.

The value of employment for people with mental retardation and other disabilities is well documented:

- Relationships. Work is where people develop relationships, friendships, and acquaintances with other people.
- Identity. Much of who we are and how we are perceived by others is related to where we work and what we do at work.
- Meaning. Our society values work. By working people with mental retardation and other disabilities feel that they are engaged in meaningful activities, as do others in that society.
- Self Esteem. Through work we often have a sense of accomplishment, increasing our sense of competence and self worth.
- Economics. Most people with mental retardation live in or near poverty. Income from paying jobs helps supplement their resources and improves the quality of the lives they can live.

We know that work is valuable. We know that many people with disabilities want to work and that they need support to do so. What then must be done to assure that more people are able to access employment and supports they need? While there are a number of potential strategies, many of which have and are being tried with limited success, The Arc of Tennessee proposes an *Employment First* initiative:

- Employment should be the first “day service” option for adults in Division of Mental Retardation Services (DMRS) Medicaid or State funded supports. By looking at employment as the default service, it becomes necessary to demonstrate why another service or support would be selected by the individual or the Circle of Support. While it

would be possible to receive other services, creating an expectation of people working would lead to a significant increase in employment.

- As new services are funded for people coming off of the waiting list, the *Employment First* strategy means that the primary new service becomes supported employment, not day habilitation, community participation, or personal assistance. In an environment of limited resources, the most valued services should be funded first.
- Supported employment and employment related activities should receive adequate funding that is easy to access for individuals and is flexible enough to use in a variety of situations. This includes the short-term funding available through the Division of Rehabilitation Services and the long-term funding through DMRS.
- Over the next three (3) years fifty percent (50%) of people in Medicaid or State funded “day supports” should participate in supported employment.

In implementing an *Employment First* initiative, a number of barriers to employment will have to be addressed and overcome. It will be necessary to develop a significant level of cooperation between government, providers, advocates, families, individuals, and employers. And, while the *Employment First* initiative will not result in everyone working, it will be a significant step forward to supporting people to reach a life filled with meaning and achievement.